

diaspora is thrilled to bits. However, a last session of poor batting leaves India nursing a loss, one that grants a 2-1 lead to Australia in the Border-Gavaskar Trophy series.

Bradman reigns

It is time for Sydney and a tryst with the New Year festivities. All roads lead to the Sydney Harbour Bridge to witness the fireworks at the stroke of midnight. There is a rush, roads get closed, walking is the lone option, and cafes and pubs are packed. A night wanes; suddenly the



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skies light up. It is 2025, and pictures of the festivities, perhaps the first on earth, will be the preferred page-one snap across the globe.

The return hinges on public transport like trams and cabs. The first dawn of the year is spent in a tizzy. A train is caught to Bowral, a town two hours away and famous for being the place from where Don Bradman emerged. Almost a one-horse outpost, there is warmth and nostalgia, and the people offer instant guidance to the most revered spot in town.

The Bradman Oval is a lovely ground. Fringed by trees and with a distant hill as a signpost, it is rural in heart and eternal in its appeal. Old-timers are more than willing to talk about the great Don, obviously tales they heard from their parents. The Bradman Museum has a duality; it offers homage to the great batter and equally celebrates the willow game, its history, the rules, and the players, who made it what it is today.

The Rohit question

The return to Sydney goes in a blur, and it is time to dip into the



fifth and final Test. The Sydney Cricket Ground (SCG) is a stunning venue and seamlessly blends the old wing with the refurbished stands. This is a hat tip to old architecture and modern demands while the aesthetics aren't lost.

On match eve, Gautam Gambhir doesn't commit to whether Rohit Sharma will be part of the playing eleven. This is the captain, but the coach doesn't budge.

All scribes become body-language analysts. Every move of Rohit's is scrutinised. He arrives at the nets, banters with Bumrah, and later returns with his kit and bats against throwdowns.

There is no clue as to whether he will play or not. As the day lapses into night, conflicting reports emerge. He may play, he is dropped, he is rested, and oh, he has opted out. Finally at the toss, Bumrah strides out; the team list doesn't have Rohit's name.

It is bizarre, and the entire incident could have been handled

Old-school charm: The Bradman Oval is rural in heart and eternal in its appeal. K. C. VIJAYA KUMAR

better. India loses the game, and while it is in progress, through a television interview, Rohit says that he opted out. The match has some angst too as Konstras gets under the skin of Bumrah, who in turn dismisses Usman Khawaja.

Unfortunately, a back spasm lays Bumrah low, and he cannot bowl in the second innings. This is a sliver of fortune for the Aussie batters. Pat Cummins and his men win the Border-Gavaskar Trophy at 3-1. The dust settles, copies are filed, and a night is spent well, thanks to a party organised by the Australian cricket writers for their Indian counterparts.

Sports writers, like photographers, have their codes of unity cutting across their work schedules. This is a tribe always on the move, quick to write and easy to laugh. And it is time to say goodbye to Australia.